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XBMC

Build your very own entertainment system in XBMC with this quick and easy-to-follow guide

Charles McColm

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BIRMINGHAM - MUMBAI

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About the Author

Charles McColm is the leader of a community-based computer refurbishing project. He got his start in computing, like many of his generation, on the Commodore 64. In 1983, Charles joined *The Barrie User's Group*, a Commodore computer club. Club members were open with their projects and code, something that would later inspire him to be a part of the free and open source movement.

Charles first started using Linux when his brother brought home a Slackware 96 CD. Initially, it was the large collection of communication software on the CD that attracted Charles' attention. Later, the free software philosophy and community were what influenced him the most.

Charles met Marcel Gagne, author of several Linux books, at the *Kitchener Waterloo Linux User Group* and later went on to review a couple of chapters of Marcel's *Moving to Free Software* before it went to press. *Instant XBMC* is Charles' first book.

Charles became interested in XBMC when he needed to find a better solution to the mass of CDs and DVDs spread throughout several rooms. His wife and son are much happier for it. They stream music and video to the TV connected server and use XBMC to entertain from time to time.

This book wouldn't have been possible without several people. Firstly, I would like to thank Priyanka Salvi for finding me. Having read Packt Publishing books before, I was honored to be asked to write a book for Packt Publishing. I would also thank Harsha Bharwani for guiding me through the early stages of the book and for making me seem more eloquent than I am. Esha Thakker kept me on schedule, focused, and answered all my questions about the book's content; thank you as well. Of course, the XBMC community, developers, wiki authors, and those who've contributed to the forums, all must be thanked for making XBMC great. Finally, I would like to thank my wife, Maria, and son, Leo, for bearing with me after working most of the day and writing during my free time in the evenings. I would also like to thank the rest of my family for their love and encouragement to pursue my passion over the years. And a special thank you to everyone from Packt Publishing who've seen this book to fruition.

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About the Reviewer

Werner Ziegelwanger, MSc was born in 1984 and studied Game Engineering and Simulation. He got his Master's degree in 2012. His Master's thesis was published with the title: *Terrain Rendering with Geometry Clipmaps for Games*, *Diplomica Verlag*. He works as a self-employed programmer and writes his own blog (`http://developer-blog.net`).

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Instant XBMC

Welcome to *Instant XBMC*. This book has been especially created to provide you with all the information that you need to get set up with XBMC. You will learn the basics of XBMC, get started with building your first course, and discover some tips and tricks for using XBMC.

XBMC is one of those programs that looks simple, but has a host of features that don't get used much. This book attempts to rectify this by getting you speed on topics, such as the quickest way to install XBMC on a new system, preparing and adding movies, television shows, and music, playing content from Internet sources, beautifying XBMC with skins, and streaming using phones and tablets.

As we become increasingly connected, we consume more and more multimedia content on a variety of devices. We're not just sitting in front of the television and the DVD player anymore, but watching and listening to media on notebooks, phones, tablets, and other smart devices. Convergence of media across these devices grows more important. Your smartphone might be limited to 16 GB of storage, but imagine for a moment, being able to play at the touch of your screen 2 TB (or more) of your digital media library available whenever you connect to your wireless network; that is the power of XBMC.

We use XBMC in a variety of ways for entertaining. Some guests want to see a slideshow of pictures accompanied with music. Other guests are more partial to playing music videos. And when children come, we hook them up with a children's movie which we know will entertain them (usually). It's for those friends who've asked how they can get their own XBMC system up and running that this book is for.

XBMC has a very simple looking interface. Underneath the hood, it isn't so simple. Setting up XBMC can be a chore, especially on difficult hardware or when it comes to playback codecs for different multimedia formats. What do you do if things don't look right? Although this book is meant as a quick guide to XBMC, I have touched on solving some of these problems so you can get XBMC up and running quickly.

This book is written in a linear fashion. You can read it from start to finish.

This book contains the following sections:

So, what is XBMC? gives you a sense of what really makes XBMC so popular. Find out what XBMC actually is, what you can do with it, and why it's so great.

Installation covers how to choose the right hardware (or version of XBMCbuntu for your existing hardware), how to install XBMCbuntu with a minimum of fuss, and what to do if the display doesn't look right. You will learn how to download and install XBMC with the minimum fuss and then set it up so that you can use it as soon as possible.

Quick start – media files and XBMC covers the basics of XBMC, such as how to name and organize your media so XBMC will correctly scrape information about it, adding media to XBMC via Samba or SSH, setting up XBMC to scrape metadata about your media collection, a couple of ways to play content back, and changing XBMC's default skin to better suit your tastes. This section will also show you how to perform some of the core tasks of XBMC; for example, adding pictures, music, and video from local and network sources.

Top 6 features you need to know about helps you learn about some of the cooler, but challenging features, such as playing streaming Internet content via add-ons; streaming content from your iPad, iPhone, or iPod to XBMC via Airplay; streaming to other devices via Universal Plug and Play (UPnP); watching TV from Internet sources; adding third party repositories for more add-ons and skins; and changing metadata sources, so if one goes out you have another to rely on. Here, you will learn how to perform five tasks with the most important features of XBMC. By the end of this section, you will be able to change the appearance of XBMC using skins; change the online source from where XBMC gets artwork and metadata; download and install add-ons for Internet content streaming; enable Airplay so you can stream your music and movies from your iPod, iPad, or iPhone; and enable UPnP to stream content from your XBMC machine to your smartphone or tablet.

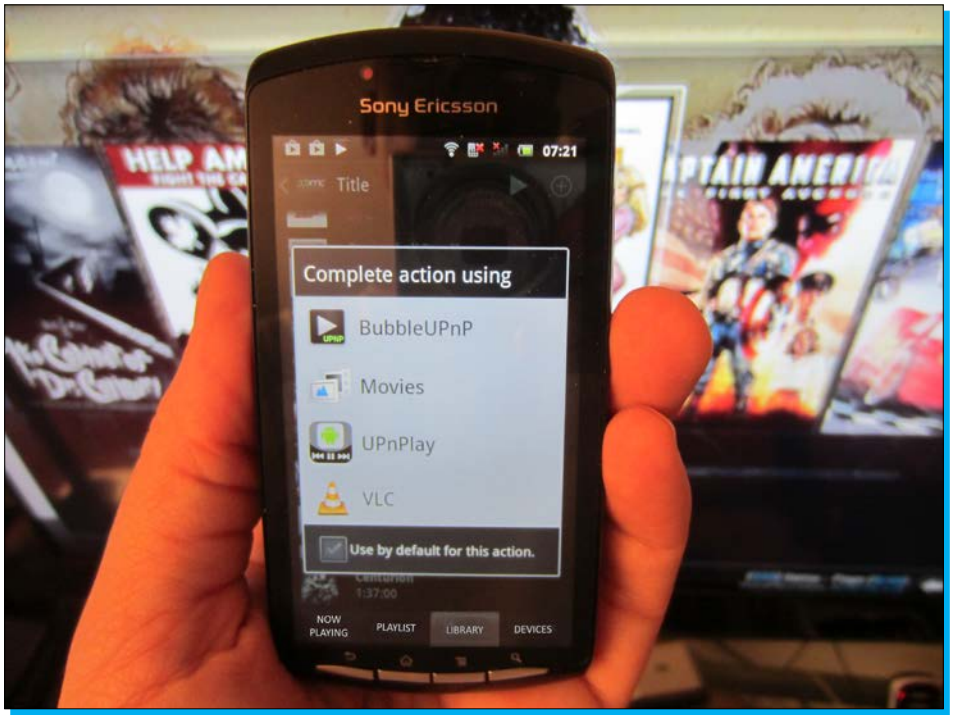
People and places you should get to know lists every open source project that is centered around a community. This section provides you with many useful links to the project page and forums, as well as a number of helpful articles, tutorials, blogs, and the Twitter feeds of XBMC rockstars. XBMC has an amazing community, so amazing that it has spawned several distributions of XBMC, and on any given day, at any given time you can find approximately 500 people in the XBMC Internet Relay Chat channel on Freenode. Look on YouTube and you'll find hundreds of videos on XBMC-related topics. It's a project that generates a lot of excitement. If you ever get stuck, there's an enormous community backing XBMC and several ways to get more information: wiki, forums, and chat. Many of these sources are documented at the end of *Instant XBMC*.

So, what is XBMC?

XBMC is a software media center for playing and streaming multimedia content. There are lots of multimedia centers available, but only a few can run on the range of hardware XBMC can run on and few can play the number of formats it can play. Besides playing a large number of video and music file formats, XBMC can display pictures and show the weather conditions for most of the major cities in the world. Add-ons extend its capabilities so you can listen to Internet radio, watch Internet videos, play games, interact with Facebook, check your Gmail account, or even control ambient lighting in your living room.

XBMC is designed to look great on big screen televisions, but it also looks and works surprisingly well on modern notebooks, tablets, and phones. Official versions of XBMC are available for Mac OS X, Windows, Linux, Android, Apple TV (jailbroken) boxes, the Raspberry Pi, iOS (jailbroken devices), and as a prepackaged complete Linux + software solution. XBMC is licensed under the GNU General Public License v2 or later, which means you can even download the source code and modify XBMC if you wanted to. Boxee, another well-known media center, was originally a fork of the XBMC code.

Once properly configured, XBMC automatically scans collections of videos and music and fetches movie, television shows, and music metadata. Want subtitles? XBMC can download those too. Got an iPod, iPad, or iPhone? You can stream content from those devices to your XBMC computer using Airplay, Apple's proprietary protocol stack for streaming audio, video, and photographs. Using **Universal Plug and Play** (**UPnP**) you can even stream from your XBMC computer to your phone or tablet; so no matter where you are in your house or business (Provided your XBMC machine is on the same network), you can watch your movies or television shows, or listen to your music collection.



Best of all, XBMC can be controlled from your iPod/iPad/iPhone, Android device, Windows phone, or with common Windows Media Center remote controls making it easy for anyone in the house to navigate to the type of content they want to watch. This also means as long as you have your phone or iPod handy, you'll never be without a remote (where did that remote go?).

Downloading the color images of this book

We also provide you a PDF file that has color images of the screenshots/diagrams used in this book. The color images will help you better understand the changes in the output. You can download this file from `http://www.packtpub.com/sites/default/files/downloads/6869OT_Instant-XBMC.pdf`

Installation

Versions of XBMC are available for a number of operating systems and hardware. We'll concentrate on installing the XBMCbuntu, the official Linux + XBMC distribution of XBMC, as it can be installed on most desktops or notebooks that have been made within the last five years. XBMCbuntu can be run on its own as a "Live" media center off a USB key or installed to a hard drive. There are two official versions of XBMCbuntu:

- For AMD-based systems
- For Intel or NVIDIA-based systems

We use the XBMCbuntu Intel/NVIDIA version, but the installation steps apply equally to both versions.

Minimum hardware requirements

Current minimum hardware requirements for XBMC can be found at: `http://wiki.xbmc.org/index.php?title=XBMCbuntu`. On PC architecture, the XBMC project suggests a minimum of at least a Pentium 4, Pentium M, Athlon XP/64, AMD Opteron, or newer processor. For 1080p playback, the project recommends a fast dual core processor. Although XBMC can run on a Linux or Windows system on an Athlon XP, Athlon XP CPUs do not support SSE2 instructions that modern versions of Adobe Flash use.

The project also provides the following recommended video card minimums:

- ATI Radeon R420 (X800)
- Intel GMA 950 (945G)
- NVIDIA GeForce 6-series

XBMC can run on a variety of hardware. A few specialized Linux + XBMC distributions exist for the Raspberry Pi, an inexpensive tiny computer with an HDMI output. If you're running XBMC on a Raspberry Pi, we highly recommend *Raspberry Pi Media Center* by *Sam Nazarko*, *Packt Publishing*, which covers some of the nuances of setting up Raspbmc. For this book, we assume you're installing XBMC on PC hardware. We tested our installation on:

- A Dell Inspiron Mini 1012 netbook, Intel Atom N450 (1.66 GHz single core) CPU, 1 GB RAM, Intel GMA 3150 graphics (VGA out) 256 MB, and a 250 GB hard drive.
- A custom-built PC consisting of an Asus P5K SE motherboard, Pentium D 3.2 GHz CPU, 4 GB DDR2 800 RAM, Asus (NVIDIA) 210 Silent 1 GB DDR3 video card (HDMI, DVI and VGA out), a 320 GB SATA hard drive (for the OS), and a 2 TB SATA hard drive (for data).

We connected our XBMC media centers to a Samsung 42 inch LCD (LN40A330J1D) television via DSUB/VGA and HDMI. When connecting via VGA, we also need to connect from the green speaker/audio out on the netbook and PC to the green audio in the television. When connecting using HDMI, the additional audio cable is not needed, as HDMI carries both audio and video signals.

Installation steps

The following are the installation steps involved:

1. Download the XBMCbuntu ISO image.
2. Create a bootable XBMCbuntu USB key.
3. Set your computer BIOS to boot from USB.
4. Boot and install XBMCbuntu.

You can install XBMCubuntu from a DVD, but many devices, such as netbooks, don't have DVD drives, and installing from the USB key is significantly faster than installing from DVD.

Step 1 – downloading XBMCbuntu

Depending on whether you have an AMD, Intel, or NVIDIA based graphics card, you'll download one of either the XBMCbuntu-XX.XX.Intel-AMD or XBMC-XX.XX.Intel-NVidia ISO (where XX.XX is the version number, in our case 12.00).

Download XBMCbuntu from `http://www.xbmc.org/download/`.

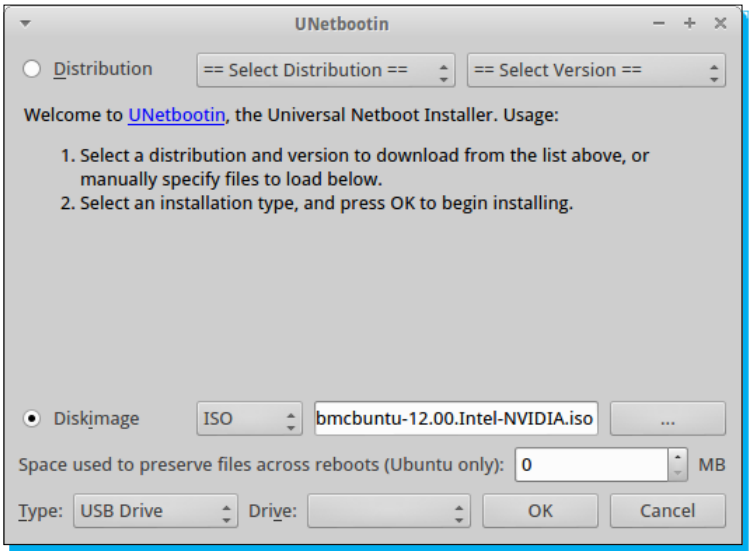
Other official versions of XBMC exist and can be downloaded from the same page. While XBMC can often be found in popular Linux repositories, these versions are often out of date or don't install the proprietary video drivers nor remote control drivers that XBMCbuntu does. We recommend you download the latest XBMCbuntu, as the project is always making improvements. XBMCbuntu provides a complete media center in a box solution that takes care of setting up extras such as compatibility with a Windows Media Center remote control.

Step 2 – creating a bootable XBMCbuntu USB key

While a variety of tools are available to create bootable XBMCbuntu USB keys on different platforms, the most straightforward solution that works across all platforms is **UNetbootin**. To create a bootable USB key on Windows, Linux, or Mac OS X, we follow the steps mentioned here:

1. Download and install UNetbootin from `http://unetbootin.sourceforge.net/` (or your software repositories in Linux).
2. Run UNetbootin, select the **Diskimage** option, select our image and USB key, and click on **OK** to make our key.
3. Unmount/safely remove our USB key.

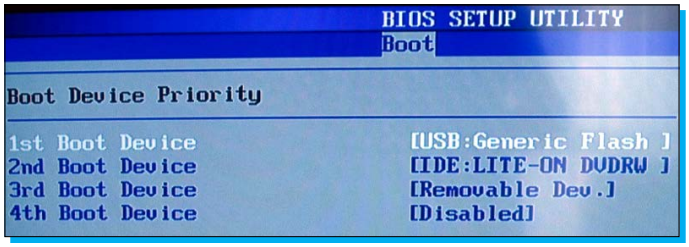
Once you've downloaded UNetbootin, insert a blank 2 GB or higher USB key and run UNetbootin. The **Distribution** radio button is selected by default. Click on the **Diskimage** radio button, and then click on the button with three dots to select the `XBMCbuntu-XX.XX-Intel-NVIDIA.iso` (where `XX.XX` is the version of XBMCbuntu you downloaded) or AMD ISO image you downloaded earlier.



The last step is to choose the USB key in the **Drive** selection underneath where the ISO image appears. If no USB key appears in the selection, check to make sure the USB key works and is at least 2 GB.

Step 3 – setting your computer BIOS to boot from USB

Computer BIOS differ from manufacturer to manufacturer. In all cases, you need to hit a key just after your computer starts up, but before Linux or Windows loads. Dell, for instance, uses the *F2* key to enter the BIOS, IBM uses the *F1* key, HP/Compaq computers use the *F10* key, and most generic manufacturers use the *Delete* (delete) key.



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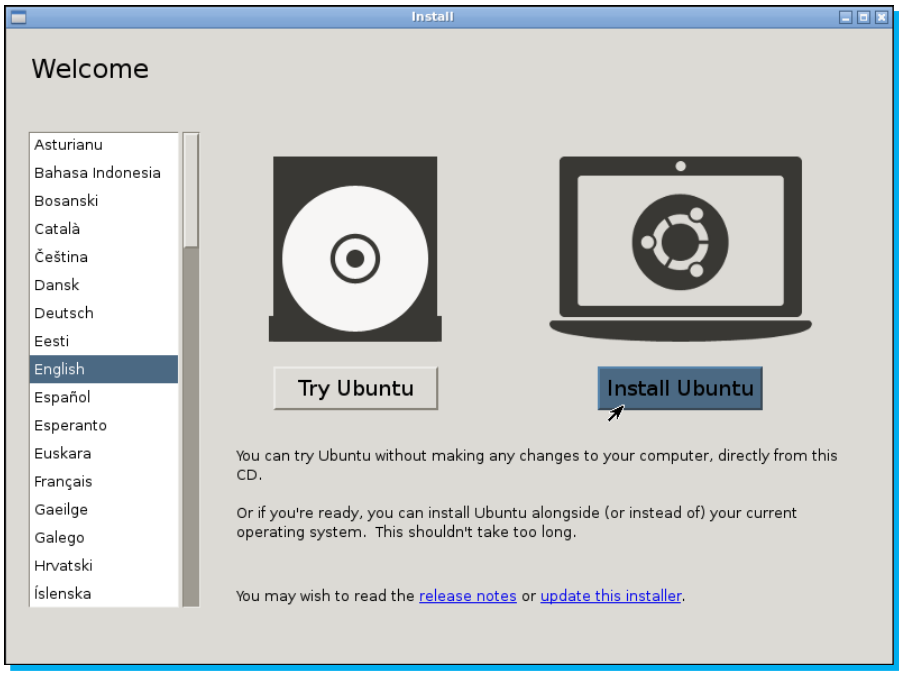
Computer BIOS vary from manufacturer to manufacturer. Look for an option to set the boot order. From the **Boot Device Priority** menu you can set the USB key to boot first. Once you've set the USB key to be the first boot device, save and exit; you should see XBMCbuntu starting to boot when your computer reboots.

Step 4 – booting and installing XBMCbuntu

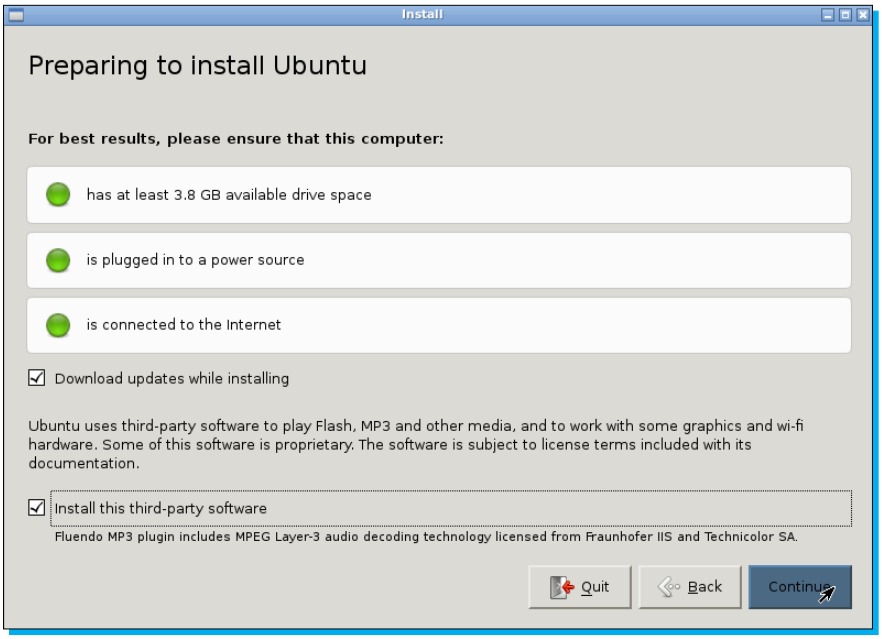
If XBMCbuntu loads correctly, you'll be prompted to **Try Ubuntu** or **Install Ubuntu**. If things don't look right, refer to the section entitled *And that's it*. If everything is good, click on **Install Ubuntu**.



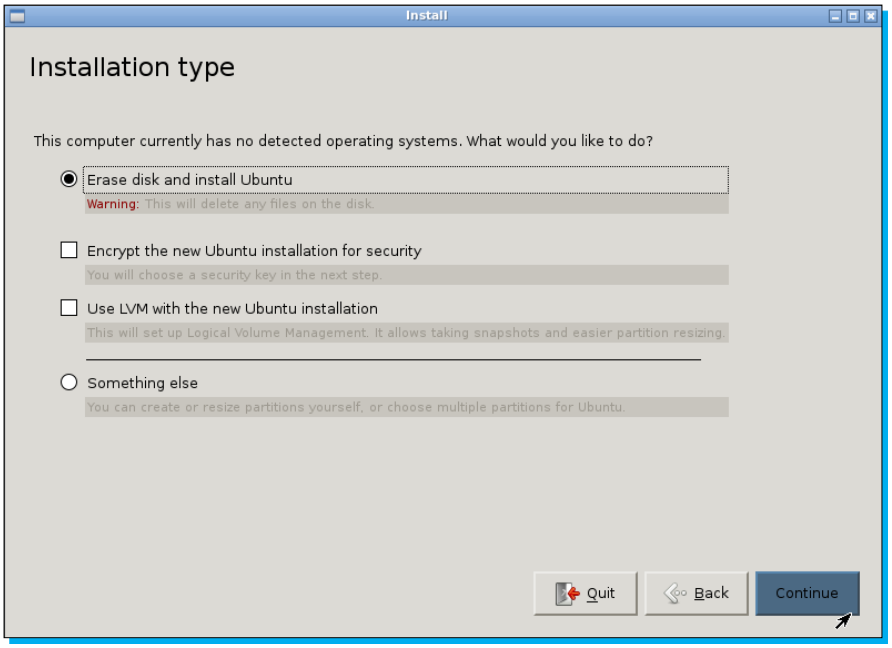
Next, XBMCbuntu displays the **Preparing to install Ubuntu** screen; select the following:

- **Download updates while installing**
- **Install this third-party software**

This step will install any proprietary drivers (for example, wireless) and the fluendo codec for MP3 playback, and then click on the **Continue** button.

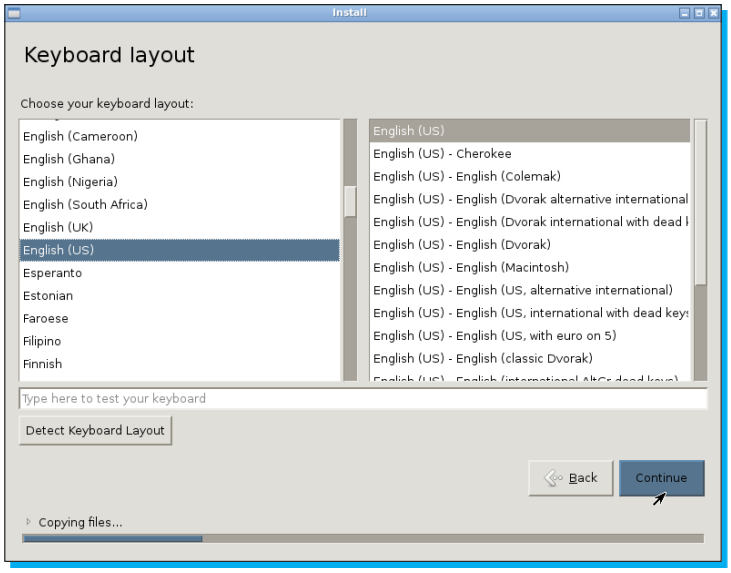


Now it's time to select the installation type. At this stage it's time to delete anything that was on the hard drive you're installing to and create a new installation. Click on the **Erase disk and install Ubuntu** radio button and then click on **Continue**.

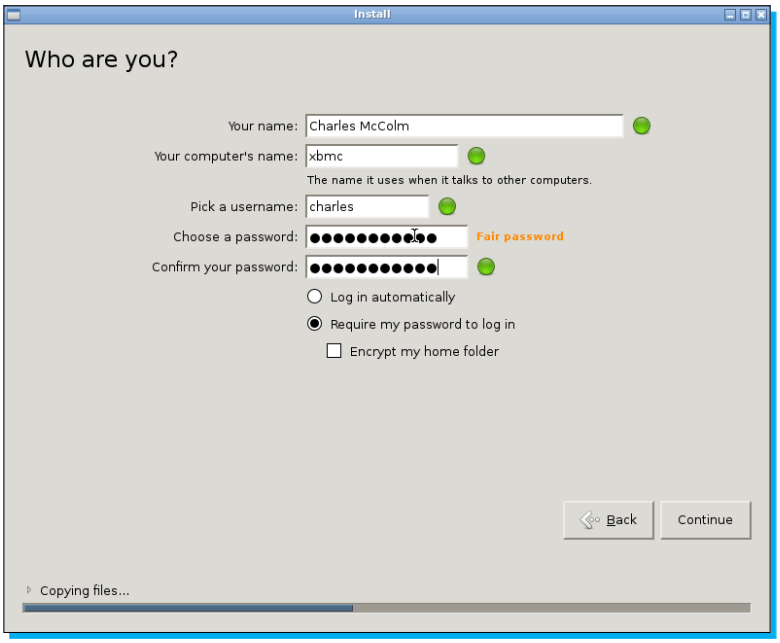


Once you click on the **Continue** button, XBMCbuntu will format the drive and begin installing XBMCbuntu. We still have a few details to wrap up, but at this point you'll notice formatting, copying, and installing activity at the bottom of the display (as shown in the next screenshot). Our next job is to select the city closest to us on the **Where are you?** screen.

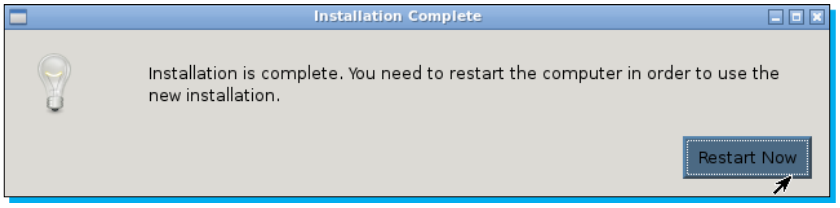
The next screen, **Keyboard Layout**, asks you to pick the type of keyboard you have. Choose your language first from the language drop-down list, choose your keyboard layout from the keyboard layout dropdown, and then click on **Continue**.



We're almost done. The last information that you need to enter is about your name, username, password, and the name of the computer you're installing XBMCbuntu on. Give some thought to the computer name you give your XBMC machine because you'll be using it when accessing the machine from other machines on your network. Click on **Continue** when you're done.

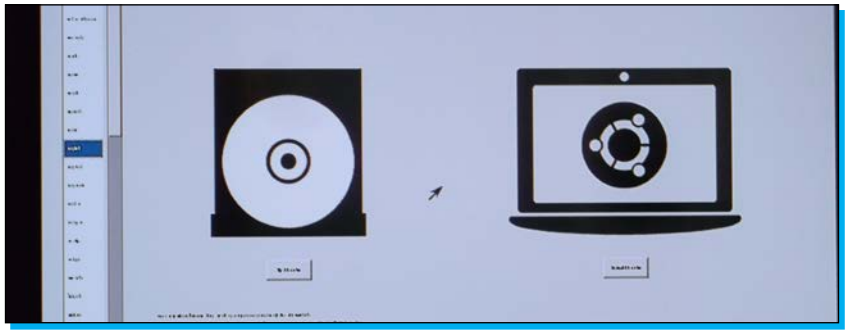


After you've clicked on the **Continue** button, XBMCbuntu will continue to install. During the install XBMCbuntu displays a slideshow of information. Once XBMCbuntu has finished installing, you'll see the **Installation Complete** dialog box. Click on the **Restart Now** button to restart your XBMC system.



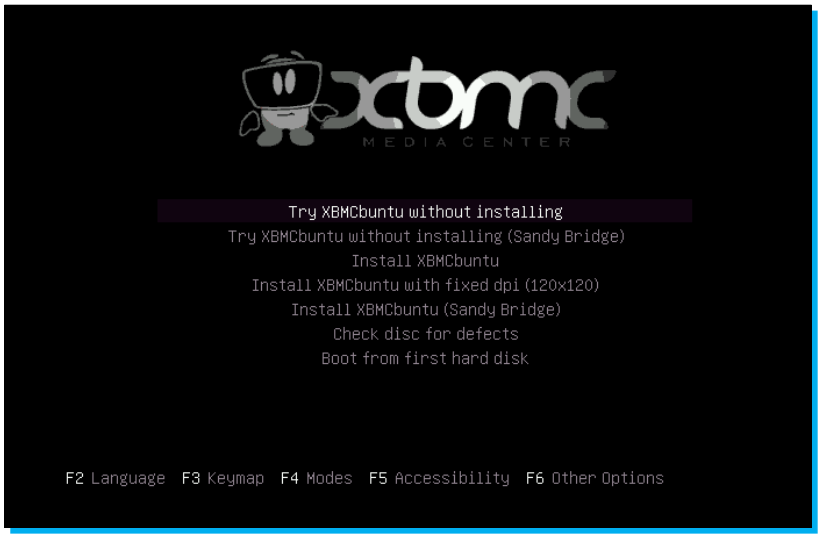
And that's it

Congratulations, you've just installed XBMCbuntu!



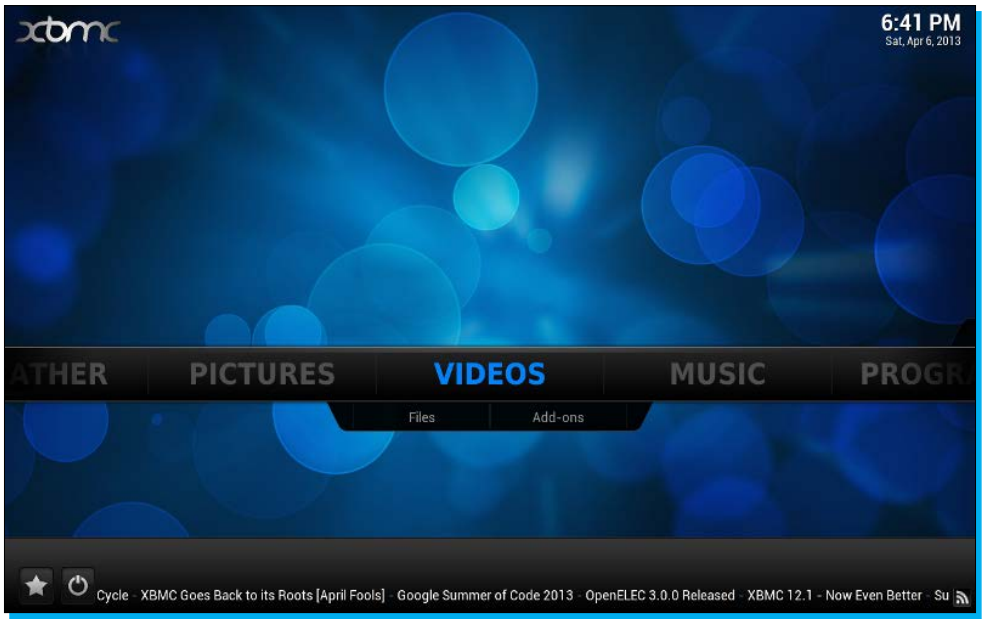
XBMCbuntu is a great installer, but it's not always perfect. In a few cases, XBMCbuntu doesn't correctly get the **Extended Display Identification Data** (**EDID**) when connected to an LCD television. Basically, XBMCbuntu just doesn't understand what kind of LCD television you have. If this happens to you and the installer displays only tiny unreadable text (as shown in the preceding screenshot), try rebooting.

When XBMCbuntu first accesses the USB key, there is a brief pause before the installer loads. During this brief pause, you'll see a keyboard and accessibility icon at the bottom of the screen. If you hit the keyboard, you'll be presented with a text-based menu. From this menu try the **Install XBMCbuntu with fixed dpi (120x120)** option. If you're still having a problem with tiny text, try connecting a DSUB/VGA cable instead of HDMI, or try installing on an LCD monitor before installing to an LCD TV.



Quick start – media files and XBMC

XBMC can be set up to look up the metadata for movies, television shows, music videos, and music; but before lookups are possible, XBMC needs a way to recognize what to look up. For movies, music, and television shows XBMC uses the filename and date as a basis for the lookup. Music needs to be tagged properly with a tag editor for XBMC to be able to understand what to look up. You also need a way to get your media files from your computer to your XBMCbuntu system. We'll be sending files over a network using FileZilla, an FTP/SFTP program, and by using Samba (drag-and-drop) shares. Lastly, we'll add your copied data to your movie, TV show, or music library.



Step 1 – naming or tagging media correctly

Before you dive into adding your movies, television shows, and music, it's important to have properly formatted media. XBMC can automatically download (scrape) information about movies, television shows, and music videos, but it needs to have a consistent way of figuring out what the name of the movie or TV show is. Movies and television shows need to be named in a particular way and music needs to be tagged with a proper ID tag, in order for XBMC's scrapers to correctly identify each media.

Naming movies

Movies should be named with their name, followed by parenthesis containing the year when each movie was released. For example:

- `\Movies\The Odessa File (1974).mp4`
- `\Movies\The Day of the Jackal (1973).mp4`
- `\Movies\Shrek (2001).mp4`

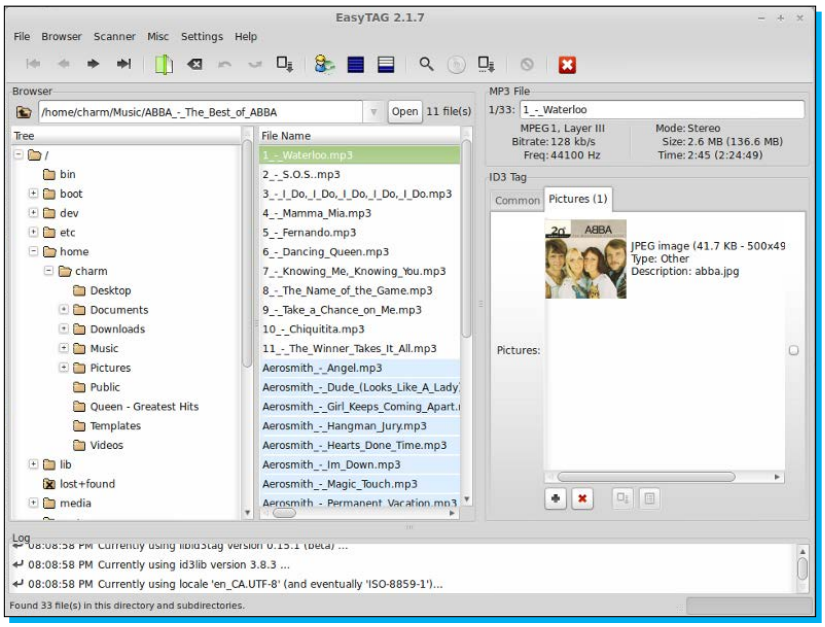
Naming TV shows

Television shows are normally kept in subfolders and each show is named with its name, the season, and the episode number. The format is `Directory\Showname.s##.e##.file extension`. For example:

- `\TV\Futurama\Futurama.s03e01.mp4`
- `\TV\Futurama\Futurama.s03e02.mp4`
- `\TV\Futurama\Futurama.s03e03.mp4`

Tagging music

In order for XBMC to correctly scrape information about a song, the song needs a proper ID tag. ID tags are metadata about the song information, such as the artist, album title, song title, and song number. Programs like iTunes, Winamp, or EasyTAG (shown in the following screenshot) can be used to tag songs before they're uploaded/added to your XBMC library.

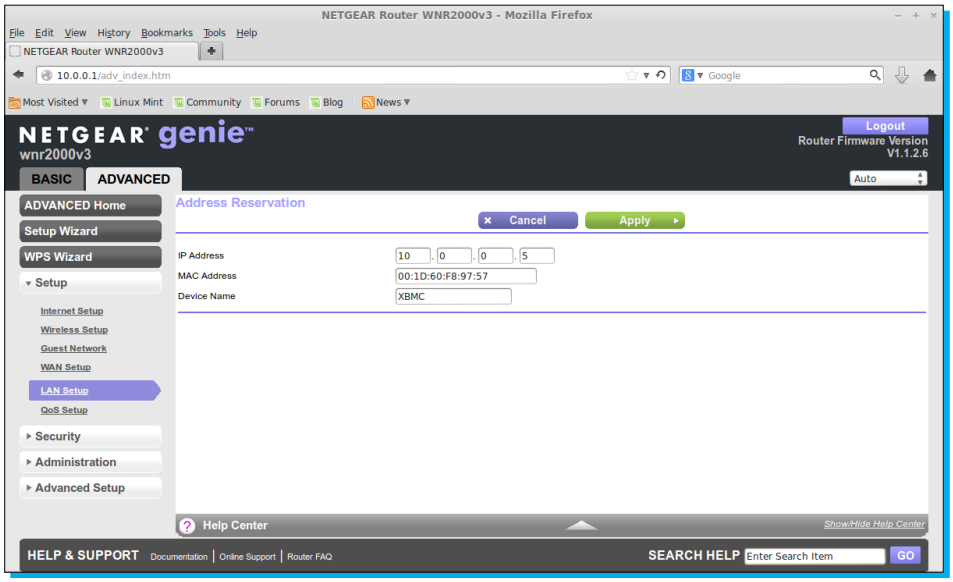


Step 2 – getting the files to your XBMC computer

If you've installed XBMC on a computer you use on a regular basis for ripping your music and video collection, you can skip to the *Step 3 – adding files to your movie, TV show, or music library* section. If you've installed XBMCbuntu to a separate computer, you need a way to get files from your desktop computer to your XBMCbuntu Media Center. Remember the computer name, username, and password you used during the XBMCbuntu installation? We're about to use that information. Because XBMCbuntu is based on Linux, there are several ways we can transfer files to our media server: NFS, Samba, SFTP, FTP, and a host of different services. For simplicity, we'll concentrate on SFTP and Samba.

Name resolution

You can see what IP address your XBMC media center is using by selecting **System | System Info | Summary**. Using your IP address you can send files to your XBMCbuntu via SFTP using a program like FileZilla or WS_FTP. But if you use DHCP, this gets a bit tedious when your IP address changes. Normally, you want to just use your XBMCbuntu computer name for SSH/SFTP and file sharing activities. Setting up DNS is beyond the scope of this Instant guide, but there are a couple of things you can do to help with name resolution. Most routers have an option to assign a name to a system with a particular MAC address (which you can see on XBMC by navigating to **System | System info and Network**). In the following screenshot, I've added a static DHCP reservation for my XBMCbuntu machine called **xbmc**. I found the MAC address by checking my router's **Device list** menu. If you're comfortable with the Linux command line, you can also obtain the MAC address of your network card by typing `ifconfig` (on Windows machines you can do the same at the command prompt by typing `ipconfig`). A router's menus and options vary depending on the router you use, but many have a section where you can assign DHCP reservations to a particular computer so it always gets the same address.



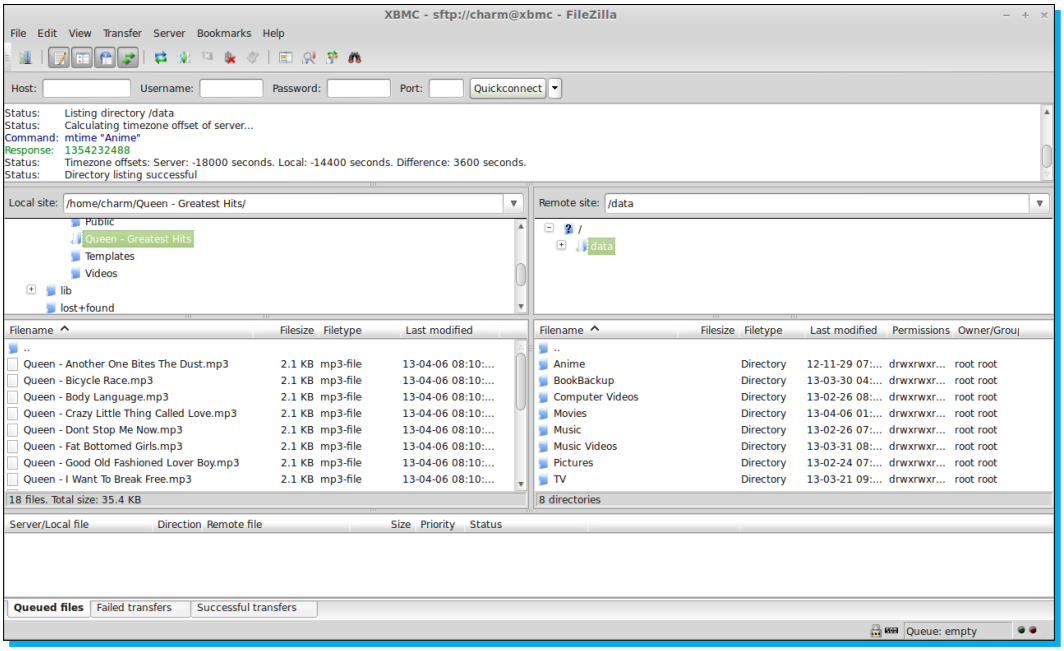
You can make Windows computers see your XBMCbuntu system with one simple modification to your XBMC system. Edit the file **/etc/nsswitch.conf** and on the line that begins with hosts, add the word `wins`.

Sending files via FileZilla

FileZilla is a cross-platform, multiprotocol client for sending and receiving files from servers. Other clients exist, but FileZilla is licensed under the GPL license and available for Windows, Linux, and Mac OS X. Download FileZilla from `https://filezilla-project.org/`, or if you're using a Debian-based flavor of Linux, just type in the following command in the console:

```
sudo apt-get install filezilla
```

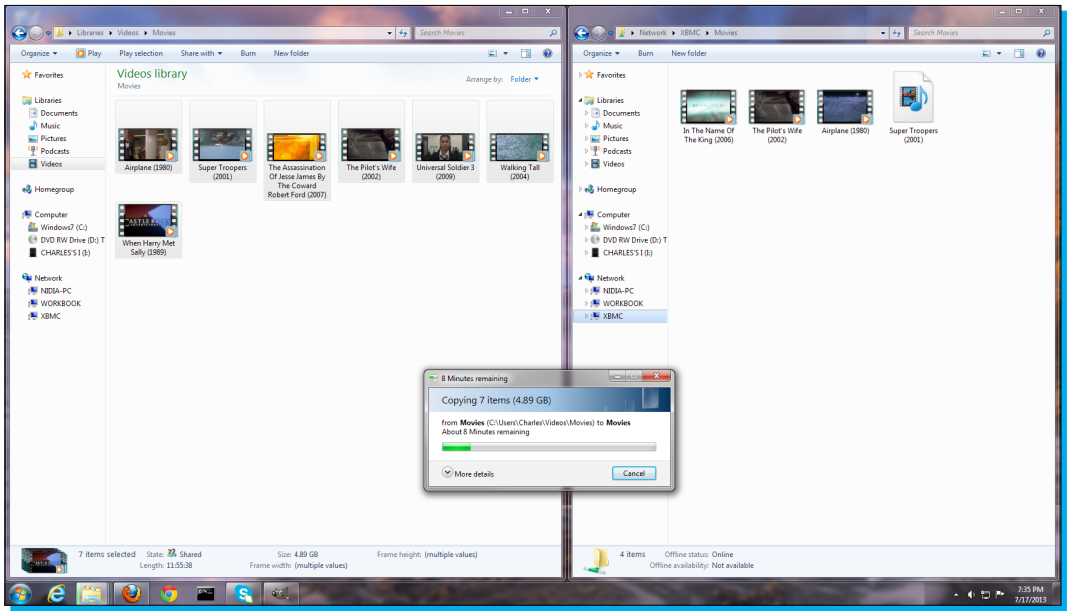
Once FileZilla is installed, navigate to **File | Site Manager** (or just click on the Site Manager icon, the first icon). Enter the hostname you gave your XBMCbuntu machine in the **Host** section. Select **SFTP | SSH File Transfer Protocol** from the **Protocol** section. Select **Normal** from **Login Type**. In the **User** field enter the username you used when setting up XBMCbuntu. In the **Password** field enter the password. Click on **Connect**.



Once connected, local files default on the left-hand side of the screen and remote files on the right. Navigate to the files and folders you want on each side. To send a file, simply right-click the file and select **Upload**. You can upload multiple files using *Ctrl* and clicking on the filenames, and then right-clicking and selecting **Upload**.

Configuring and sending files via Samba

One of the reasons to use XBMCbuntu is that it sets up movies, music, TV shows, downloads, and system folders in your home directory and adds them to the `Samba smb.conf` configuration file. Samba is a suite of tools for interoperating with Windows systems. Samba is not a part of a normal Linux install, so if you're setting up XBMC manually under Linux, you'll need to install Samba, create a Samba password for your account, and set up each Samba share for movies, television shows, and music. This is one of the things that comes preconfigured on XBMCbuntu. XBMCbuntu saves you the steps of having to download Samba, create accounts, and configure shares. Linux understands Samba too; you can open a nautilus or nemo session, hold down *Ctrl* and press *L*, and type `smb://yourservername/` to open a session. If you cannot see your XBMCbuntu Samba shares from your Windows system, make sure you've added WINS to the `/etc/nsswitch.conf` file; check to see that the NETBIOS name is the name you gave your XBMCbuntu system, and that the workgroups are the same on your Windows and XBMCbuntu machine.



To send a file to the XBMCbuntu system from a Windows 7 machine, perform the following steps:

1. Click on the **Libraries** icon in the taskbar.
2. Under the **Network** section of the window that opens, click on the NETBIOS name of your XBMCbuntu server and choose the folder you want to copy to.
3. Drag files from where you have them stored to the XBMCbuntu network folder you just opened.

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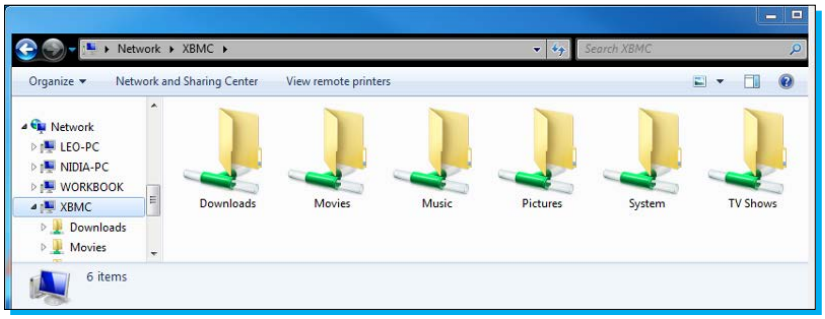
Depending on how much data you're copying, the process may take from a few seconds to several hours.

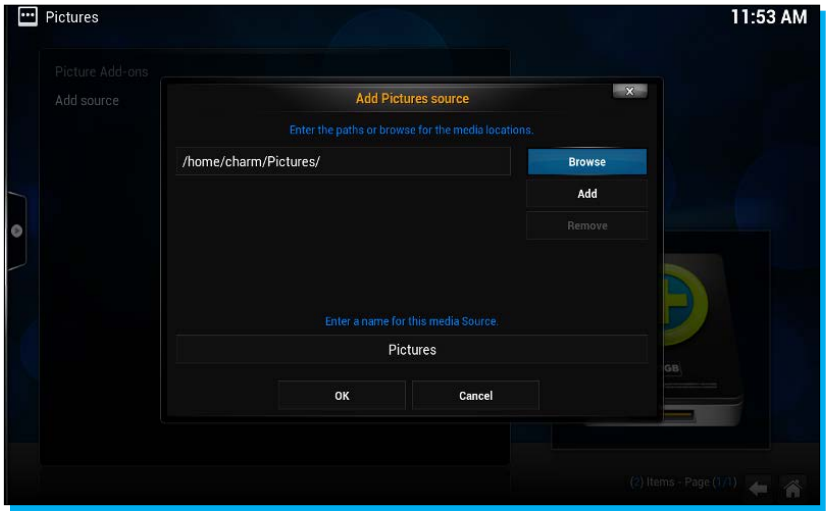


Step 3 – adding files to your movie, TV show, or music library

Once your music, movies and shows have been copied to your entertainment system, you need to tell XBMC what type of content you've added, and where to look for it.. XBMC's 10 foot interface makes adding content simple.

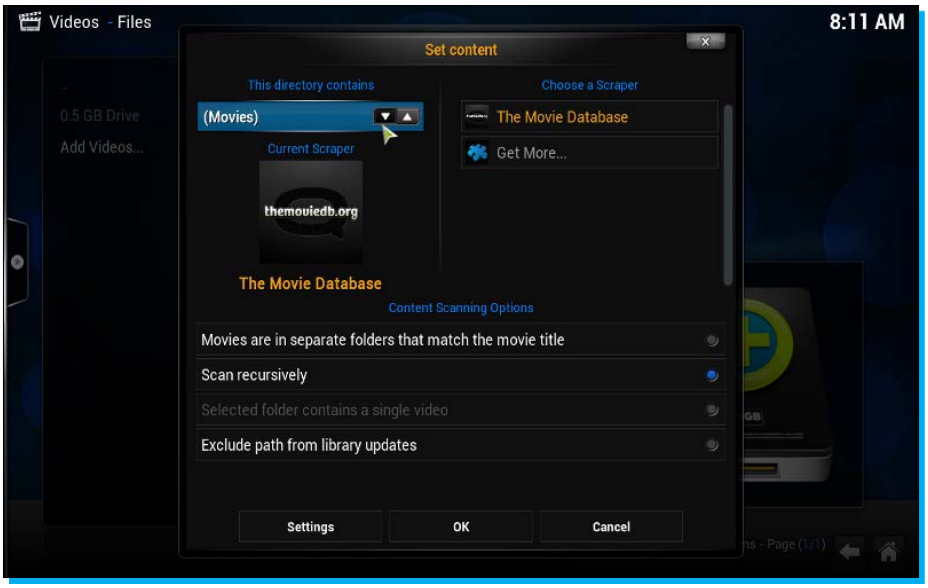
For pictures and music, perform the following steps:

1. Click on either **Pictures** or **Music** from the main menu, and then click on **Add Source**.
2. In the **Add Pictures** / **Music Source** dialog box, click on **Browse** to browse to the directory where you've stored your pictures or music. (You'll notice blue and red icons; blue icons are local sources, red icons are network sources). Once you've found the directory you stored your media in, click on **OK**.
3. Next give the source a name. You can add as many sources as you want, so it's a good idea to name them differently to stay organized.



For television shows and movies, perform the following steps:

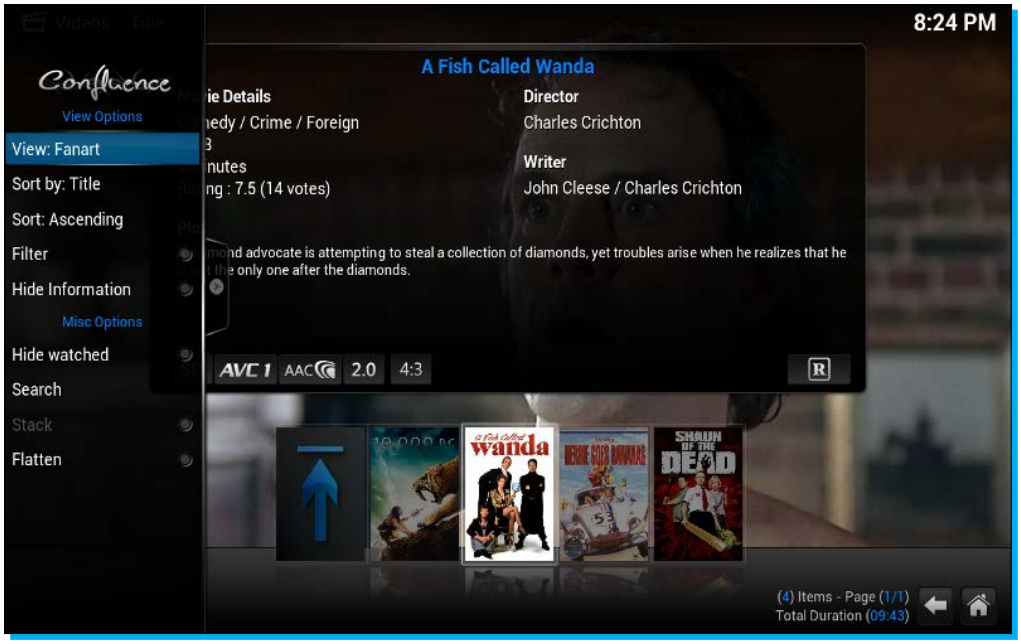
1. Click on **Videos** from the main menu, click on **Files** from the submenu, and then click on **Add Videos**.
2. In the **Add Video Source** dialog box, click on **Browse** to browse to the directory where you've stored your movies, television shows, or music videos, and then click on **OK**.
3. Give the source a name. Again it's a good idea to give the source a name that reflects the content, movies on laptop share, for example.
4. Next the **Set content type** dialog box appears showing three panels. Choose the type of video from the top-left dropdown. You can choose **None**, **Music**, **Videos**, **TV shows**, or **Movies**. As you choose the content type, the **Choose a scraper** panel on the right-hand side also changes. There is a default scraper for each video type, but you can also select **Get more** to get other scrapers for that type of content (sometimes desirable, if you're adding anime or content in another language). Select **OK** when you're done.



XBMC now attempts to add the content to its video library. If the content is correctly named, XBMC will add it to the library.

Content playback

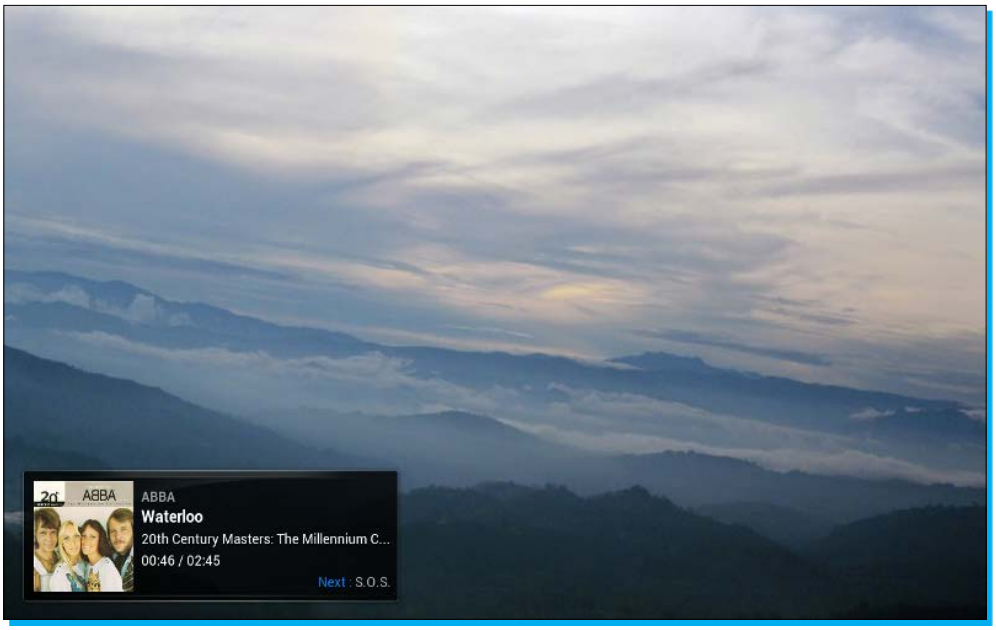
To play a movie, simply click on the movie menu option and choose the movie you want to play.



XBMC can display media in a variety of ways. Using the left arrow on your keyboard or remote control brings up the **View Options** menu. In this menu you can choose how you want video content displayed: **Poster Wrap, Fanart, Media Info, Media Info 2, Media Info 3, List, Big List,** or **Thumbnail**. Experiment with each and find out what looks best to you.

Combining photos and music

You can combine the display of photographs with music. This is useful when entertaining or when you simply want to mellow out with music and a visual display.



To play music and create a photo slideshow, perform the following steps.

Using a keyboard

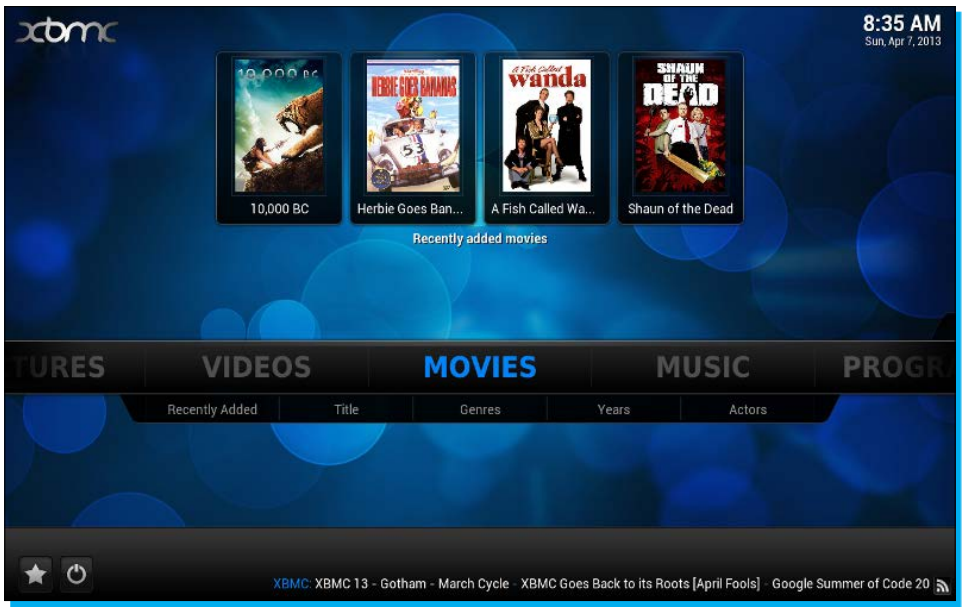
1. Select the **Music Menu** option.
2. Select the source with the music you want.
3. Queue the songs you want using the *Q* key (the first song will start playing immediately).
4. Press *Esc* until you get to the main menu.
5. Select the **Photos Menu** option.
6. Navigate to the picture folder and press the *P* key to play a slideshow of photographs.

Using a Media Center remote

1. Press the music button on the remote and choose the folder with the music you want.
2. On top of the current song press the **GUIDE** button. A long context menu will appear. Choose the **Queue item** option to queue a song.
3. Press the **PICTURES** button on the remote and choose the folder with the photographs you want.
4. Press the **PLAY** button on the remote to start the photo slideshow.

Exploring XBMC playback options

Playing music and photo slideshows is just a small part of what's possible with XBMC.



Want to watch an entire season of a television show? Queue (**Q**) the second show in the season and all the other episodes; then on the first show of the season select the **Play from here** option from the **GUIDE** button (**C** context) menu. A good resource for XBMC keyboard mappings is the XBMC wiki: `http://wiki.xbmc.org/index.php?title=Keyboard`.

Changing the XBMC skin

XBMC's default Confluence skin looks great, but like many media programs it can be skinned to look differently. A number of professional skins are available for download right within XBMC.

To download and change the current skin, perform the following steps:

1. Select **System** from the main menu.
2. Select **Appearance** from the **Change Your Settings** box.
3. With the skin selected by default in the **Appearance Settings** box, use the right arrow to move over to skin **Confluence** and select it.
4. From the skin menu that appears, select the **Get More** button at the bottom.
5. Select the skin you want. When the **Add-on Information** box appears, click on **Install**.
6. Once the skin is installed, you have the option of using it right away or not.

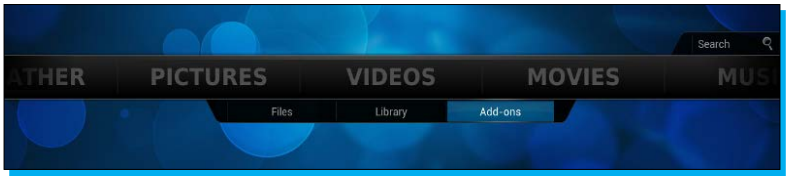
Changing the skin sometimes moves some of the options from one menu to another. So if you change skins, be aware some of the menu items might be different from what's shown here. We'll use the Confluence skin throughout this book.

Top 6 features you need to know about

Just being able to have all your movies, television shows, music videos, pictures, and music at the touch of a few buttons is pretty cool, but that's not all that XBMC is capable of. Add-ons expand XBMC's capabilities, so you can do other cool things such as playing video and music from streaming sites such as YouTube, Vimeo, or `archive.org`. Apple device owners can also stream music, videos, and photographs to XBMC and their TV by configuring AirPlay on XBMC. If that wasn't cool enough, by enabling UPnP on XBMC and downloading a UPnP application to your smartphone or tablet, you can stream video in both directions (to and from your Android or iOS device). Live TV is becoming all the rage these days and we'll look at adding FilmOn—an add-on that has some live BBC shows. With all these cool additions, we need a quick way to access some of our favorite add-ons; we'll do that by setting up convenience add-on buttons that display under the main menu. Finally, we'll add some more third-party repositories for more skins and add-ons, and we'll finish by changing the scraper where the XBMC gets metadata for movies and television shows.

Using add-ons to stream Internet content

Add-ons extend XBMC's core functionality. There are add-ons for each of the pictures, videos, and music menu options. To access the **Add-ons** menu, either navigate to the **Add-ons** submenu of the main menu using the remote control or the keyboard arrow keys:



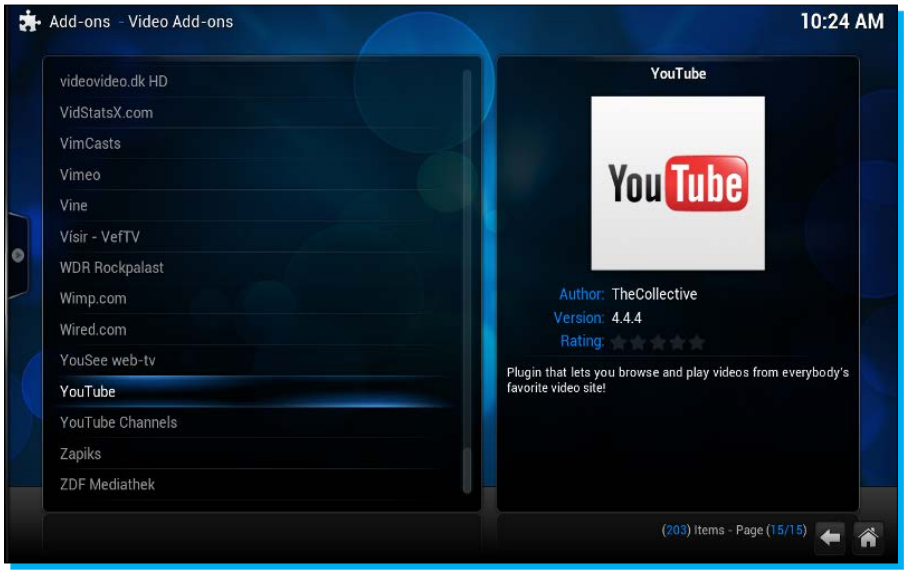
Most add-ons extend XBMC by interfacing with a website or web service. Because add-ons extend websites and services, and programmer APIs change from time to time, an add-on might be broken until the add-on developer can catch up with the site/API changes.

Once you've clicked on the **Add-ons** submenu, the **Add-ons** menu appears. If you've already added some add-ons, they'll be displayed in this submenu, if not, you'll see the following two options:

- Ellipsis to go up the menu structure
- The **Get More** option

Select **Get More...** to display add-ons for the menu category (for example, the video add-ons).

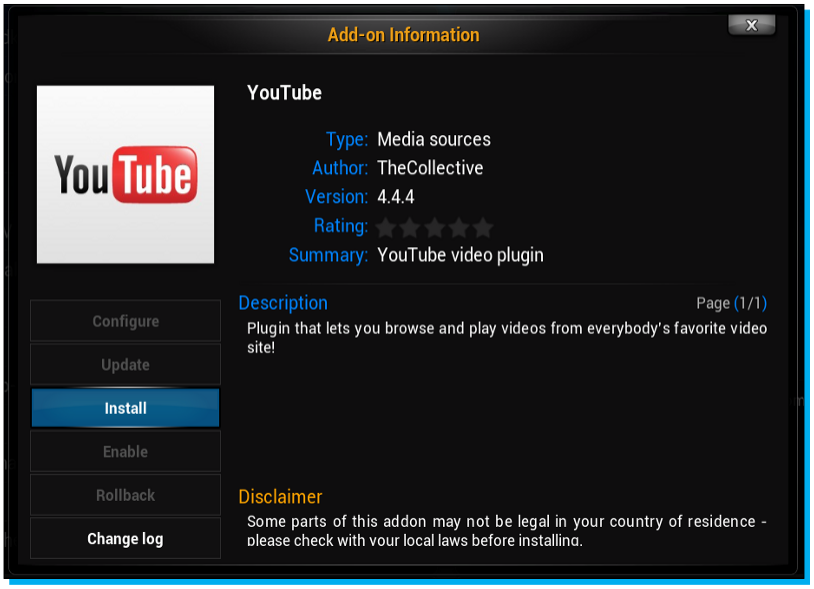
Each category—**Pictures**, **Videos**, and **Music**—has different add-ons for different services. To get more information about an add-on, select that add-on from the list. Add-ons display a graphic on the right-hand side (and sometimes a background image as well).



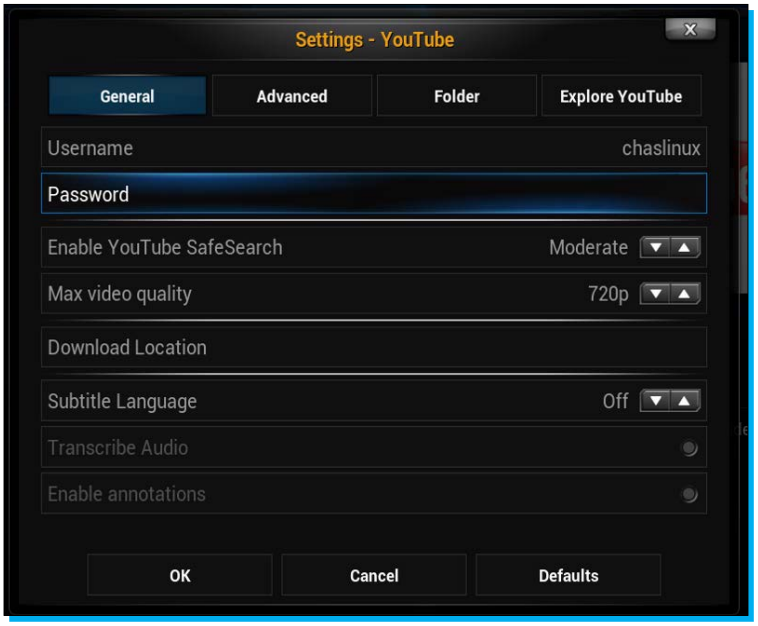
Selecting a particular add-on brings up more information about the add-on. The **Configure**, **Update**, **Enable**, and **Rollback** options are all disabled until the plugin is installed. Each add-on displays information about the following:

- Its type
- The author
- Version
- Rating
- A brief summary

- A more extensive description
- A disclaimer

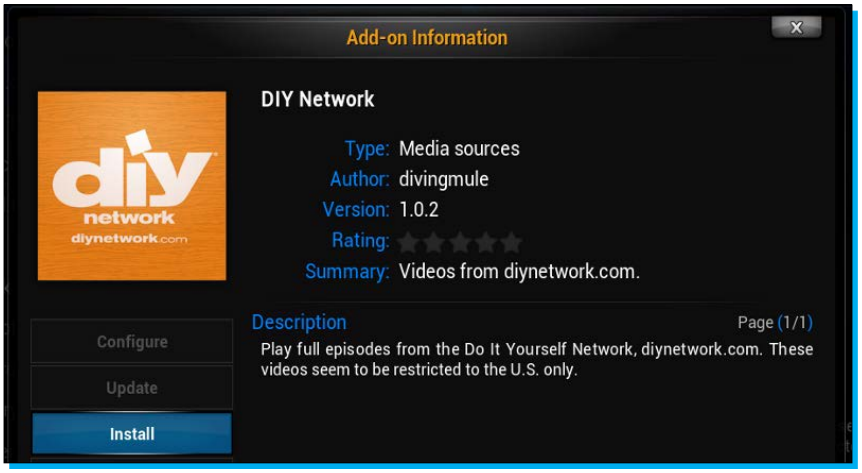


Some add-ons require configuration before they can be used. Configuration can be as simple as a username and password, or have several tabs of options:



Setting a username and password for the YouTube add-on lets you view your customized YouTube content: contacts, playlists, subscriptions, uploads, YouTube suggestions, and videos you've liked on YouTube.

Some add-ons only work in a particular region of the world. Check the add-on description and disclaimer to be sure that the add-on will work for your particular region:

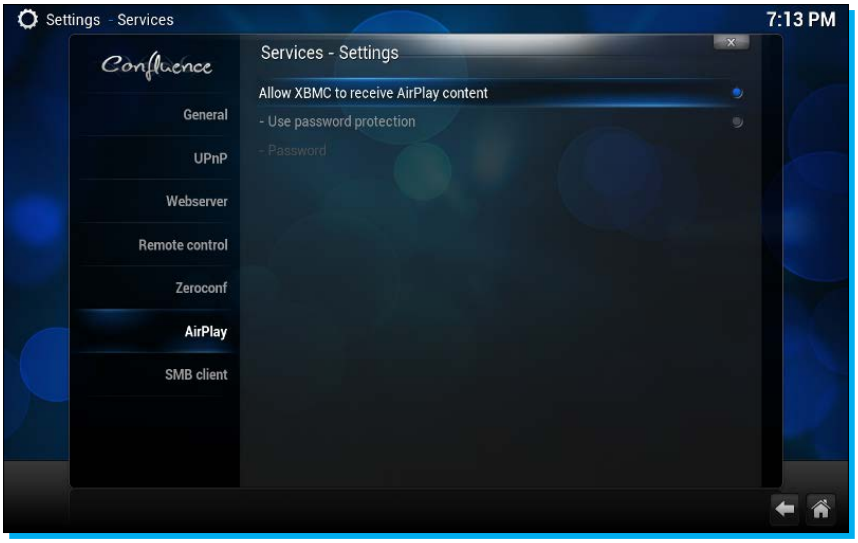


Quality of streams vary from add-on to add-on. Some streams are high definition, and some are standard definition. Also, streams that have poor compression ratios will appear to be poorer quality.

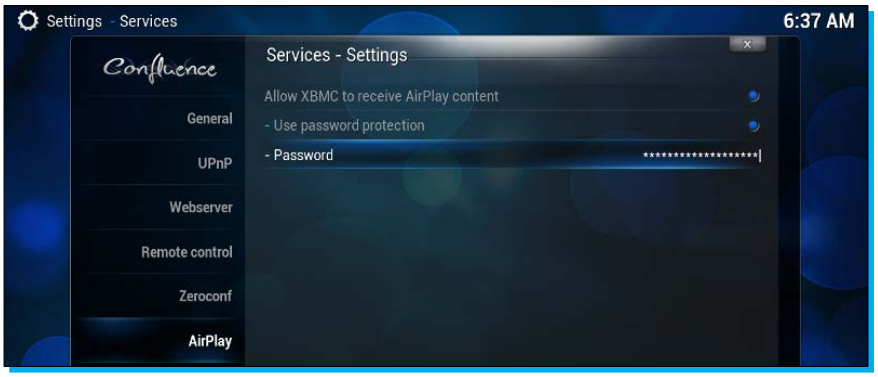
Streaming music, videos, and pictures from your iPod, iPhone, or iPad to XBMC

In the Apple ecosystem, devices can stream to each other using Apple's AirPlay proprietary protocol stack. XBMC 12 supports streaming from an Apple device via AirPlay, but the support must be enabled first.

To enable AirPlay support in XBMC, navigate to **System | Services | AirPlay | Allow XBMC to receive AirPlay content**:

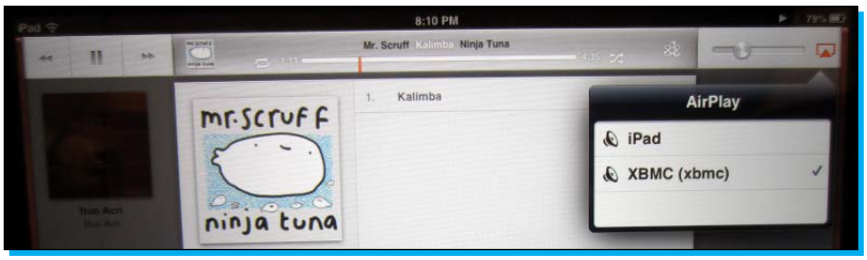


You can also set a password to prevent neighbors with Apple devices from streaming to your XBMC media center. To set a password, simply select **Use password protection**, and then enter the password. In practice, this should work, but we found that we got a playback error streaming from our iPad when we set a password for AirPlay on our XBMCbuntu machines. This sometimes happens in all software, and usually gets fixed in an updated version.



To stream from your iPhone, iPad, or iPod to XBMC, perform the following steps:

1. Select the application you want to stream from on the Apple device.
2. Play the content and press the AirPlay icon.
3. A flyout appears with the name of your Apple device, and the hostname of your XBMC machine. Select the XBMC machine name to start streaming:



Apple claims that over 50 applications support AirPlay. Popular AirPlay-enabled applications include videos, music, photos, and YouTube. For a complete list of AirPlay applications, see Apple's website at `http://theapple.tv/apps/list-of-airplay-enabled-apps/`.

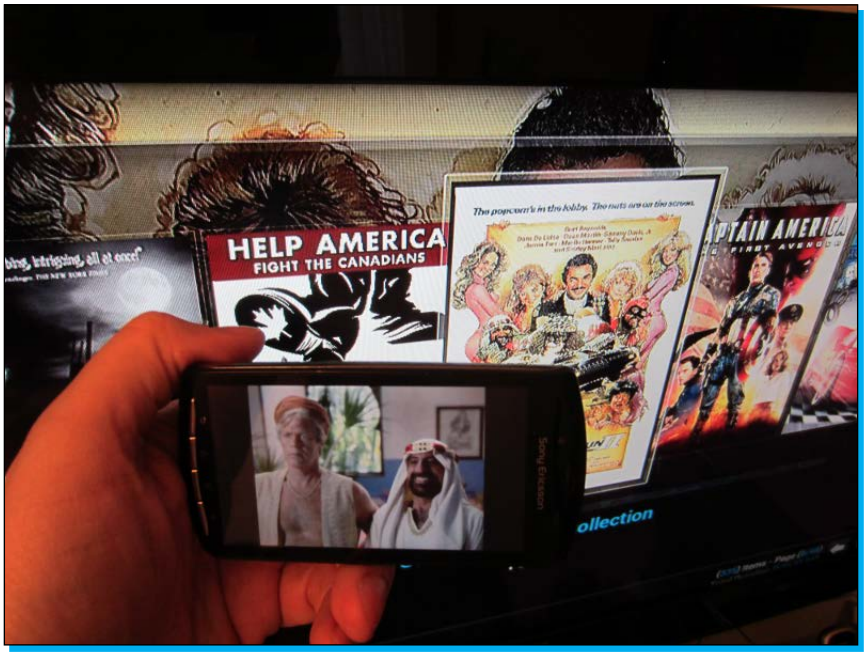
Pictures streamed from iPad to XBMC-connected TV

Airplay mirroring is not supported at the moment so playback is restricted to XBMC itself. The one exception seems to be the Photos application, which can play a slideshow simultaneously and display on XBMC.

Streaming to your Android or iOS smartphone or tablet via UPnP

Tablets and smartphones are wonderful because they're so portable. But portability comes with a cost—storage. Most of today's portable devices cannot store more than a handful of DVD-quality videos. This is where a lot of storage on your XBMC system comes in handy. Besides being able to get streams from Apple devices via AirPlay, XBMC can also stream to devices that support the Universal Plug and Play protocol (UPnP).

This means that whether you are at home or work, you can watch movies and listen to the music collection you have stored on your XBMC media center.



Streaming to your phone or tablet doesn't affect the XBMC server, so you can safely watch a video on your phone while doing another activity on the XBMC media center.

Before you can stream to your Android, iOS, or other handheld device via UPnP, you first need to follow some important steps. The steps may vary slightly depending on what phone or tablet you use. For our example, we're using an Android 2.3 phone running BubbleUPnP.

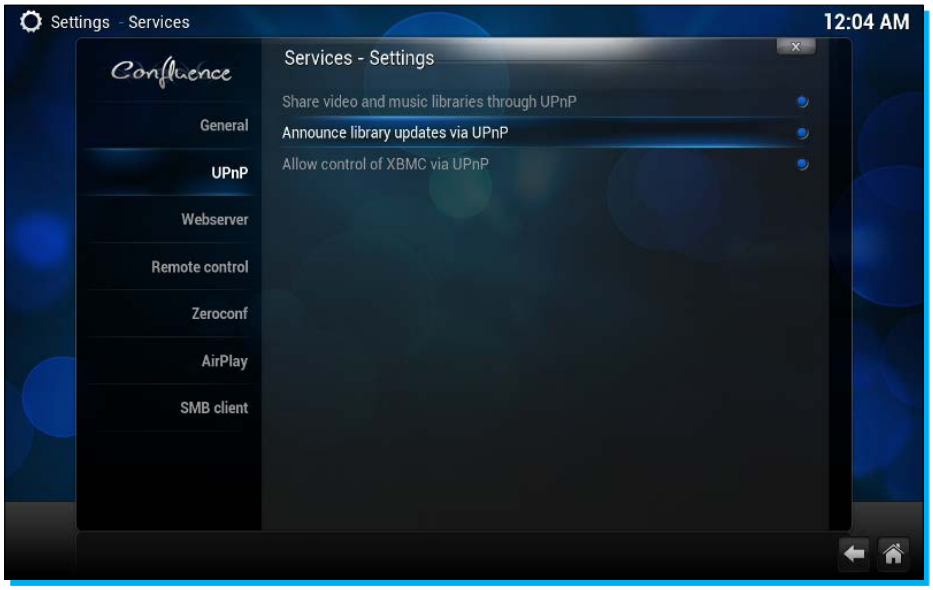
Step 1 – configuring UPnP on your XBMC media center

UPnP options are turned off in XBMC by default. There are three UPnP options, which can be set in XBMC. To access the UPnP menu navigate to **System | Services | UPnP**.

Select **Share videos and music libraries through UPnP** to be able to access your movies, television shows, music videos, and music through the UPnP protocol.

You'll probably also want to see when your libraries change on XBMC, so select the **Announce library updates via UPnP** option as well.

The third option, **Allow control of XBMC via UPnP**, allows applications that support UPnP to control XBMC. Enabling this option allows you to stream from your smartphone to your XBMC media center or another UPnP-capable device.



It should be noted that you do not need UPnP enabled on your router for UPnP to work within your own network, and it's recommended that you turn UPnP off on your router, because it presents a back-door entry for people looking to break into your network.

> Your smartphone or tablet must be connected to the same local network as your XBMCbuntu machine for UPnP to work.

Step 2 – installing a UPnP application on your handheld device

Before playing the content, we need a program that understands the UPnP service. For Android devices, we like the BubbleUPnP application. BubbleUPnP is straightforward and currently runs on older versions of Android (2.3).

Download BubbleUPnP from the Google Play Store on your Android device or at `https://play.google.com/store/apps/details?id=com.bubblesoft.android.bubbleupnp`.

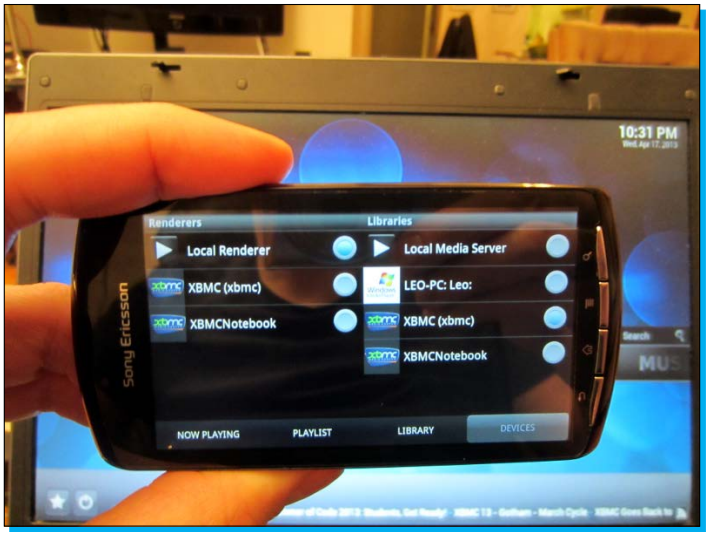
iOS users should check out 8player at `https://itunes.apple.com/ca/app/8player/id375860275?mt=8` or from the iTunes store.

Step 3 – installing media-playing software

Most phones and tablets have some sort of in-built media-playing software. Our experience is that most in-built media-playing software has a limited range of media codecs supported. On Android, Windows, Linux, and Mac OS X, we recommend using **Video Lan Client** (**VLC**) because of the wide range of codecs it supports. On Android phones, you can install VLC from the Google Play Store. For most other operating systems, visit `http://www.videolan.org/vlc/`.

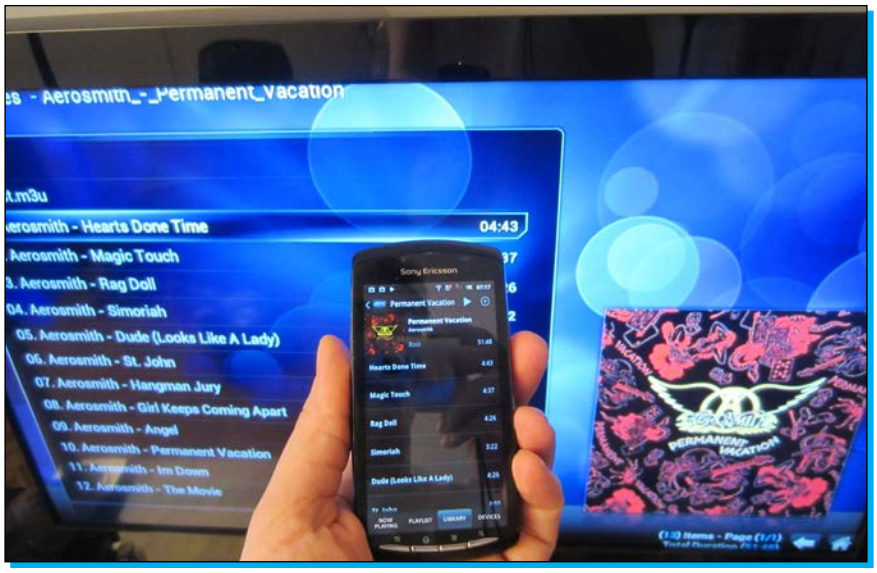
Step 4 – configuring the UPnP application on your handheld device

When you launch BubbleUPnP for the first time, you'll notice a menu bar at the bottom with four items: **NOW PLAYING**, **PLAYLIST**, **LIBRARY**, and **DEVICES**. Select the **DEVICES** menu choice. On the renderer's side, make sure **Local Renderer** is selected. On the **Libraries** side, make sure your XBMC server hostname is selected.



Step 5 – playing your content from the detected XBMC UPnP server

In BubbleUPnP, click on the **LIBRARY** menu option. Take note of the XBMC server name and the arrow at the top-left corner. BubbleUPnP displays the options: **Music Library**, **Video Library**, **Albums**, **Folders**, **Saved Playlists**, **Recently Played**, and **Random Tracks**. Choose the type of content you want. These menus somewhat closely resemble the submenus in XBMC. For example, under **Video Library**, you'll see **Movies**, **TV Shows**, **Music Videos**, **In progress TV shows**, **Recently added movies**, and so on.



Watching live TV from Internet sources

It seems that every day more and more services move online. Television is one of those services where more and more content is being reproduced and streamed online. XBMC can be used to watch TV from online services.

We'll enable streaming live and pre-recorded TV in XBMC for the FilmOn service.

Adding FilmOn is a fairly involved process that takes 20 steps to complete. We'll divide the steps into three larger steps.

Step 1 – adding the Fusion XBMCHUB repository location

To enable FilmOn, we first need to add a third-party repository (collection of software) for `fusion.xbmchub.com`. To do this we need the following five steps:

1. Navigate to the **System** menu option then select **File Manager**.
2. Select **Add source**.
3. Select the **<none>** field, and in the window that pops up enter `http://fusion.xbmchub.com/`, then click the **OK** button.
4. In the **Enter a name for this media source** option, enter `Fusion`.
5. Click on **OK**.

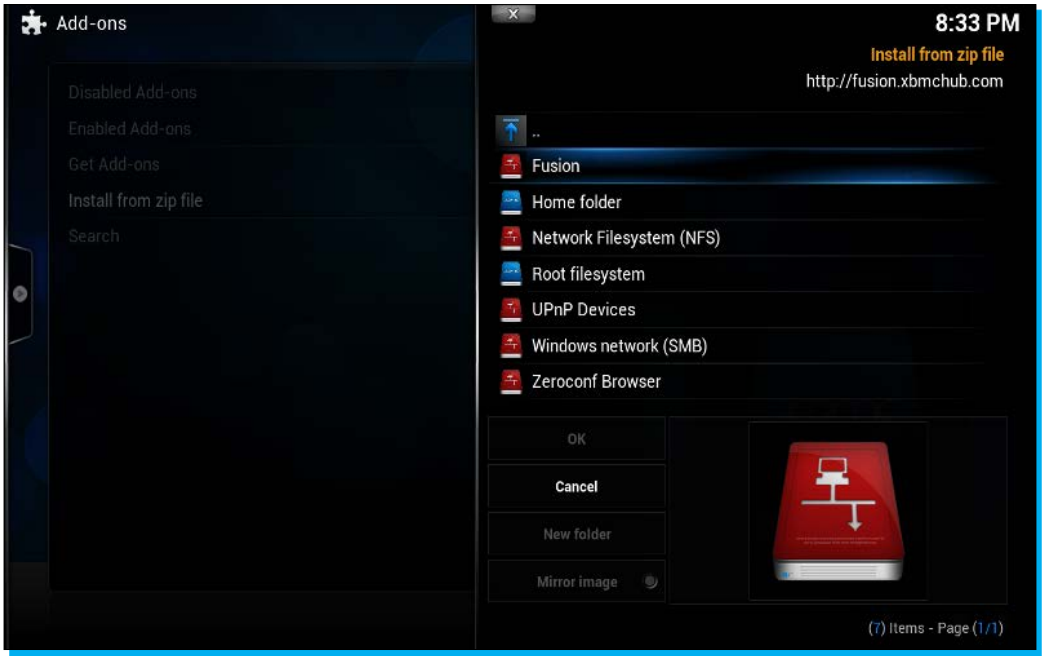
At this point we've added `http://fusion.xbmchub.com` as a network mount point.

Step 2 – installing the Fusion XBMCHUB repository ZIP file

In the next set of steps we'll install a ZIP file from that mount point that gives more information about the `XBMCHUB` repository:

1. Press the *Esc* key (or back arrow on your remote) until you're at the main XBMC menu.
2. Select **System** then select **Add-ons**.
3. Select **Install from zip file**.

4. Select the red Fusion drive/mount point.
5. Navigate to and select **Video**.
6. Navigate to and select **Repositories**.
7. Navigate to and select the repository that begins with `repositories.xbmchub`. The ZIP file will install.



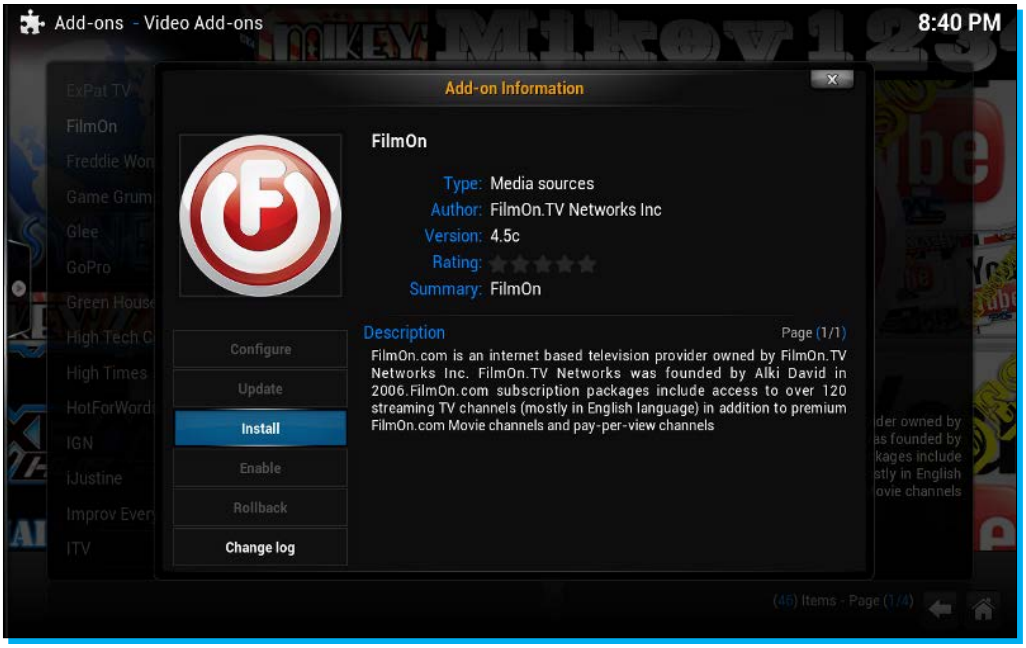
A notification will appear in the bottom-right-hand corner of the screen notifying us about whether or not the repository installed.

Step 3 – installing and enabling FilmOn

At the time of writing there were 46 web services available through the `fusion.xbmchub` repository. To enable FilmOn, perform the following steps:

1. Select **Get Add-ons** from the **Add-ons** menu.
2. Select **XBMCHUB.com Add on Repository**.
3. Select **Video Add-ons**.

4. Navigate to and select **FilmOn**.
5. Click on **Install**.



At this point FilmOn is installed and available.

To play channels from FilmOn, return to the main XBMC menu, select **Videos**, select **Add-Ons**, and then select the **FilmOn** add-on.

Once you've installed a bunch of add-ons, navigating through these submenus can be a bit of a pain. XBMC lets you assign up to five add-ons to the main screen for each of pictures, videos, and music.

Adding convenience add-on buttons to the main menu has changed since XBMC Version 11. In XBMC 12 and later, for adding convenience add-on buttons, perform the following steps:

1. Select **System**.
2. Select **Appearance**.
3. Select **Skin**. Navigate to and select the **Settings** option on the right-hand side just under **Skin**.
4. Navigate to **Add-on shortcuts**.

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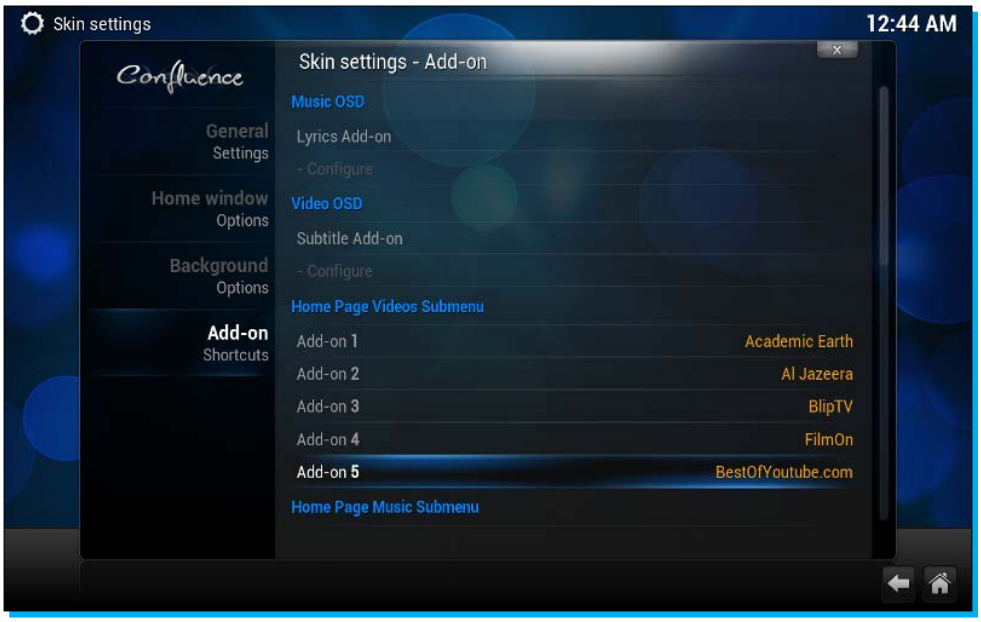
5. Navigate to **Add-on 1** through **Add-on 5** for each of **Home Page Videos**, **Home Page Music**, **Home Page Pictures**, and **Home Page Programs** to select an add-on to appear under the main menu for each option.



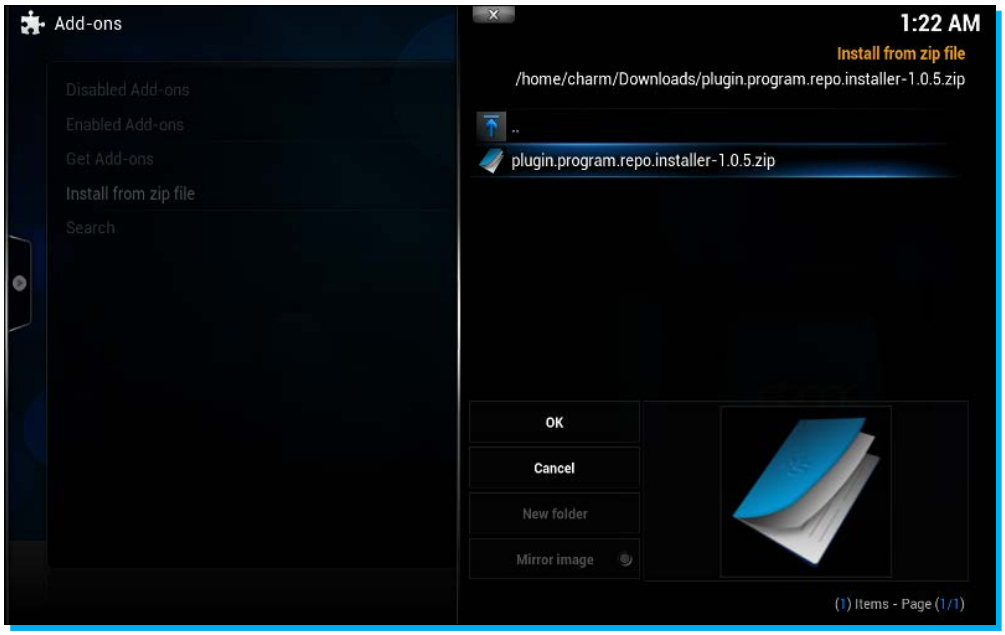
Step 4 – adding third-party repositories for more add-ons and skins

XBMC maintains a list with a large number of third-party repositories for different add-ons and skins at `http://wiki.xbmc.org/index.php?title=3rd_party_add-on_repositories`.

You've already added the Fusion XBMCHUB repository if you completed the steps under the *Watching live TV from Internet sources* section. We could repeat similar steps for each of these repositories, but there's an easier way as shown in the following steps:

1. On your XBMC machine download the required file from `http://passion-xbmc.org/addons/Download.php/plugin.program.repo.installer/plugin.program.repo.installer-1.0.5.zip`. (I use SSH and wget to download plugins, but you can also transfer them from your main computer using FileZilla or Samba, as we did with our media data earlier).
2. Select **System**.

3. Select **Add-ons**.
4. Select **Install from zip file**.
5. Navigate to your `Downloads` folder where you saved the `plugin.program.repo.installer-1.0.5.zip` file and select it.
6. **Escape** out to the main menu.
7. Select **Programs**.
8. Select **Repository Installer**.



Now you can select from many of the repositories listed on the XBMC site. Alternatively, if you don't want to install the repository installer plugin you can download each ZIP file listed on the wiki link provided earlier and install each individually.

Step 5 – changing the metadata scrapers for movies and television shows

In XBMC, metadata scrapers are tiny pieces of code that scrape particular Internet sources for information about movies and television shows. Occasionally, an Internet source is down or the source doesn't have a particular movie. In these cases, it's desirable to change which Internet source is being scraped. The process is basically the same for both movies and television shows. We'll change a movie scraper. First the new scraper needs to be installed.

To install a scraper for a movie source, perform the following steps:

1. Navigate to the **Videos** main menu and select the **Files** sub-menu.
2. On the source you've added (**Movies,** for example) press *c* or the guide button on your remote to bring up a context menu.
3. Select **Edit Source**.
4. Select **OK**.
5. In the **set content** dialog box, navigate to the **Choose Scraper** section and click **get more**.
6. Select the movie scraper Internet source you want.
7. Select **Install** on the **Add-on Information** screen.

Now the new Internet source is installed, but it's not enabled yet. To enable a different scraper:

1. Navigate to the **Videos** main menu and select the **Files** submenu.
2. On the source you've added (**Movies,** for example) press *c* or the guide button on your remote to bring up a context menu.
3. Select **Edit Source**.
4. Select **OK**.
5. In the **Set Content** dialog box, navigate to the **Choose Scraper** section and select the scraper you just installed.

People and places you should get to know

XBMC has tremendous community interest and has spawned at least three forks for different platforms (Raspmc, OpenELEC, and an Android and hardware-level version for the Pivos XIOS DS). The community is ever changing, but there are some people and places you'll want to know.

People

- Nate Thomas—the lead on the XBMC project. Nate does all the update information on the XBMC site. Nate can be found on the freenode XBMC channel as well as on Twitter.
- Sam Nazarko—the lead on the Raspbmc project, author of *Raspberry Pi Media Center* by *Packt Publishing*, and Crystalbuntu developer on top of being a first year Kings College student.

Canonical sites

- `http://xbmc.org/`: The main website for XBMC is updated regularly. The official XBMC downloads are available here as well as galleries of different skins, and links to the wiki, forums, and bug reporting sites.
- `http://www.raspbmc.com/`: Raspbmc is a specialized XBMC Linux distribution for the ultra cool, low cost, and tiny profile Raspberry Pi computer. This site has an active community with some really innovative Pi case designs by community members. The site owner, Sam Nazarko also happens to be the author of *Raspberry Pi Media Center*, *Packt Publishing*.
- `http://openelec.tv/`: OpenELEC is an embedded XBMC Linux distribution designed to run on small embedded devices based on Atom, ION, Intel, or Fusion chipsets.

Social networking

- `https://www.facebook.com/XBMC`: The official XBMC Facebook fan page
- `https://twitter.com/XBMC`: Follow XBMC on Twitter
- `https://plus.google.com/+XBMC/posts`: Hang out with the official XBMC crew and fans on Google+
- `https://www.facebook.com/raspbmc`: Raspbmc Facebook fan page
- `https://twitter.com/SamNazarko`: Sam Nazarko on Twitter
- `https://www.facebook.com/OpenELEC`: OpenELEC Facebook page
- `https://twitter.com/openelec`: Follow OpenELEC on Twitter
- `https://plus.google.com/+openelec/posts`: Hang out with OpenELEC on Google+

Support

- `http://wiki.xbmc.org/`: The official XBMC wiki.
- `http://forum.xbmc.org/`: The official XBMC forums.
- `http://trac.xbmc.org/`: XBMC's Trac based bug tracker.
- **#xbmc on** `irc.freenode.net`: The very active XBMC channel on Freenode IRC. There are normally about 500 plus people on the channel at any given time.
- `http://www.raspbmc.com/wiki/`: Raspbmc wiki.
- `http://forum.stmlabs.com/`: Raspbmc forums.
- `http://wiki.openelec.tv/`: OpenELEC wiki.
- `http://openelec.tv/forum`: OpenELEC forums.

Other sites of interest

- XBMC on the Pivos XIOS DS media play embedded Android computer. A good source for development news about XBMC on Android and the Pivos XIOS DS can be found at `http://www.pivosforums.com/viewforum.php?f=24`.
- Sam Nazarko's *Raspberry Pi Media Center* book found at `http://www.packtpub.com/raspberry-pi-media-center/book`.
- A site for third-party XBMC add-ons can be found at `http://www.xbmchub.com/`.
- XBMC repository on GitHub can be found at `https://github.com/xbmc/xbmc`.
- Sam Nazarko's technology blog where he writes about Linux, Windows, hardware, and other tech-related topics found at `http://stmlabs.com/`.

Software of interest

- Create bootable Linux USB keys on Windows, Linux, or Mac OS X with the UNetbootin tool at `http://unetbootin.sourceforge.net/`
- FileZilla cross-platform FTP/SFTP tool at `https://filezilla-project.org/`
- The popular open source Video Lan Client multimedia program supports a large range of codecs and works on a number of hardware platforms found at `http://www.videolan.org/vlc/`
- BubbleUPnP Android Universal Plug and Play application on the Google store can be found at `https://play.google.com/store/apps/details?id=com.bubblesoft.android.bubbleupnp`
- 8player, a Universal Plug and Play application for iOS on the Apple iTunes store, can be found at `https://itunes.apple.com/ca/app/8player/id375860275?mt=8`

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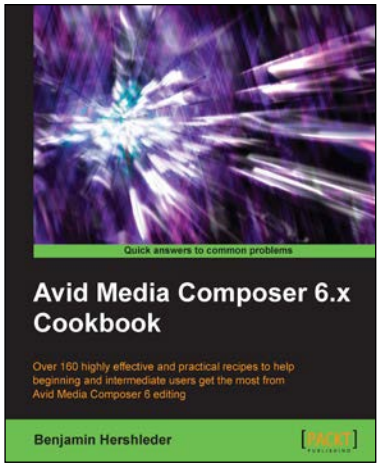

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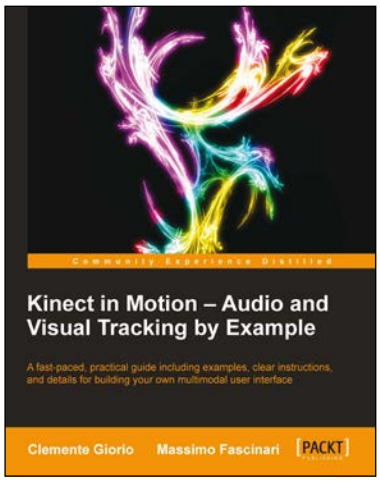

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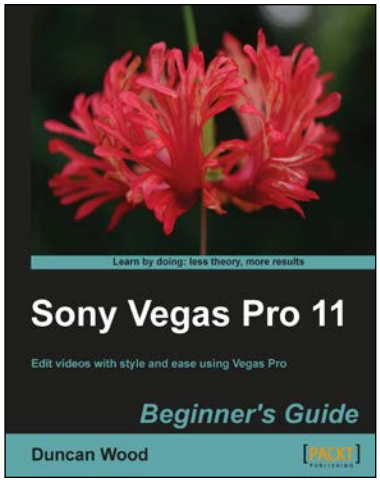

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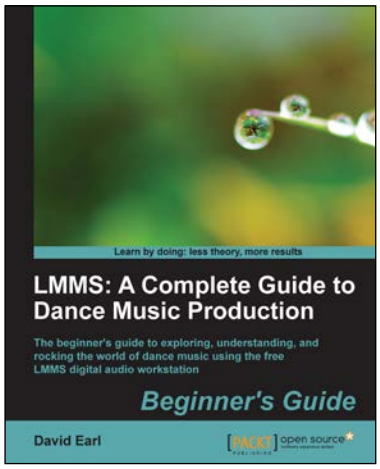

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